

Transcript of the Ash Court: Concerning *Edge of Gloamreach*

[The chamber is shuttered against the pale day. A brazier breathes low. The grimoire rests upon a stone table, bound in dark material that refuses the warmth of the coals.]

CLERK: Let the matter be spoken plainly. Let no hand touch the book without leave of the Court.

MAGISTRATE: Is the object before us the thing named *Edge of Gloamreach*?

WITNESS: It bears that name.

MAGISTRATE: That is not what I asked.

WITNESS: I have seen the name upon its cover. I have seen it in the mouths of those who fear it. Whether the name belongs to the book, or the book belongs to the name, I will not swear.

CLERK: Recorded: the witness confirms the name is present, but refuses to establish its meaning.

MAGISTRATE: Describe the object.

WITNESS: It is a grimoire bearing the name *Edge of Gloamreach*. Its pages are close-written, though the writing seems to withdraw when stared at. Its visual identity is that of a grimoire bearing the name *Edge of Gloamreach*. That is the safest description.

MAGISTRATE: You have repeated the description as though repetition makes it true.

WITNESS: In this chamber, truth is often only a sentence that survived the hearing.

MAGISTRATE: What is required to attune it?

[A murmur passes behind the screens. The Clerk pauses with the quill lifted.]

WITNESS: The attunement cost is 46.

MAGISTRATE: Forty-six what?

WITNESS: The record gives no further measure. It says only this: the attunement cost is 46.

CLERK: Entered exactly.

MAGISTRATE: And its making? Who forged *Edge of Gloamreach*? Under whose roof? For what purpose?

WITNESS: No answer is preserved.

MAGISTRATE: You evade.

WITNESS: The forging date is not recorded. Nor have I been shown a supplied fact naming its forger, its patron, or its purpose.

MAGISTRATE: Then speak of its character.

WITNESS: It suggests a shadowed and twilight-bound atmosphere.

MAGISTRATE: Suggests?

WITNESS: A book cannot be cross-examined for its mood. The darkness clings to it, or the beholder carries darkness in. I can swear to the suggestion, not to the source.

CLERK: The witness states that the demeanor of *Edge of Gloamreach* suggests a shadowed and twilight-bound atmosphere.

[The Magistrate leans toward the grimoire. No page turns.]

MAGISTRATE: Has it spoken?

WITNESS: Not in any manner I can safely call speech.

MAGISTRATE: Has it harmed anyone?

WITNESS: I will not place a claim where the record places none.

MAGISTRATE: Then why bring it before the Ash Court?

WITNESS: Because it was brought. Because the name was read aloud. Because some doors open when named, and some remain shut only until the next hand tries.

CLERK: The testimony is entered.

[The brazier gutters. The grimoire remains closed.]